

WORLD SERIES '80

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Ex-Phils Relive Baseball Times

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"Going to Philly at that point, even though I liked the town, was like being sent to Siberia."

"It was almost like being railroaded, but for another reason. I had had some trouble, had been suspended, and it was either go to Philly or give up playing in the big leagues. I think the deal involved Rudy May."

"So I showed up, cracked a rib in spring training. It was the year after they blew the pennant, and Mauch didn't want anybody in the training room, didn't want to hear about injuries. I played hurt, really struggled, and didn't produce. Didn't? I couldn't."

"But hard feelings? Hell, no. Hey, I picked 'em to win the Series in five."

Winning in '80 may have exorcised the memories of '64 for some, but not for everybody. Not for Frank Thomas, who lives in Pittsburgh, working for the ICM School of Business, visiting schools, suggesting educational alternatives.

"I came from the Mets to the Phillies, on a bus, literally," Thomas said. "We rode in to play here, I got off the bus, was told I had been traded, and just switched clubhouses."

"I went in and asked Mauch what he had in mind. He said I'd be playing against lefties, but that that could change. So I went out and got two hits off Al Jackson, and played the rest of the games in '64 until Sept. 8, when I broke my thumb."

"I broke it in the fourth inning of a game, didn't say anything, got two more hits, used ice between innings. After the game, I got a big can, filled it with ice, put my hand in it and slept that way. I woke up the next morning, it was all red and swollen, I went to the doctor."

"I told him not to tell anybody, to give me a shot of pain-killer so I could grip the ball. He said he couldn't do that, that he had to put it in a cast. So I could hit, but I couldn't throw."

"Gene asked me if I could play, I said I probably could, but that I'd hate to be in a position where I had to make a crucial throw — like to the plate — and not be able to do it. I didn't want to cost the team a game. From that point on, things seemed to go the other way."

"The next year, they got Dick Stuart, Gene told me not to worry, but he stopped talking to me. I played maybe five innings all spring. It was as if breaking my thumb had been my fault."

Thomas had some fun, challenging guys to throw their best fastballs, catching them barehanded.

"Don Zimmer was the toughest," he remem-

bered. "He took a running start, got to 60 feet, 6 inches and threw me a spitter. But I caught it, he threw his glove in the air, said he was a believer."

And then there was the unfortunate incident with Richie Allen, then a young slugger.

"What I remember," Thomas said, "is that the club handled it so poorly. For one thing, I wasn't the one who started it. And Richie, he had a chance to be the greatest player who ever lived. He used to go to Mauch, and ask that I play first, 'cause he was playing third and knew he could throw as hard as he needed to, that I'd handle it."

But one day on the field, Richie and Frank came to blows.

"Ahh, I was sucker-punched," Frank Thomas said. "I said some things I never should have said. I even went to Richie afterward, told him how sorry I was, how unfortunate it was. He told me to get away from him. I remember telling Wes Covington that I knew right then I had lost my job. Wes said it wouldn't happen, that he'd go on the radio and explain what really happened. He did, too."

"But Gene called me in, said I was being placed on waivers, that somebody would claim me. I told him it was unfair. He said, 'You're 35, he's 23.' I'll never forget that. I called John Quinn, but he said he had to stick with his manager. I was the scapegoat, and I knew it."

He sounds like a happier man now.

"I visit the schools, tell 'em that even if you play ball for 20 years, you'll only be maybe 38 when you're finished, that you've got the rest of your life to live and work," he said. "You need to be prepared."

"Take me. People told me, when I was done playing, that I'd work in baseball. They'd tell me, when it was time, to call, that there'd be something. Well, I got done and called ... called and wrote to 24 teams, got only five replies. It made me wonder."

"Is it because of the incident with Allen? I don't know what else to think. I thought, 10-15 years later, people would forget. But what happens is, they forget you."

Mack Burk was here for two seasons, batted twice the whole time, and loved it. Frank Sullivan was here in '61, suffering through a 23-game losing streak, and hating it.

Burk was a catcher who had to stay on the varsity roster because his bonus was more than \$4,000. He lives in Pasadena, Texas, a half-mile up the road from Gilley's, the famed gathering place in "Urban Cowboy."

"They're making a mint in that place," Mack



Bo Belinsky always had an eye for the ladies

said, taking a break from a busy wholesale electrical supply business. "They pack it every day ... the people who go regularly, and the ones who know it from the movie. I've been over a couple times myself."

"My days with the Phillies ... I loved 'em. I was 20, a kid, and I was in heaven. Pinch-hit once in '56, got a single up the middle against Joe Nuxhall. Then I got up against Johnny Antonelli in '58, and struck out."

"But I remember the players ... Robin Roberts, Andy Seminick, Ruben Amaro, Art Mahaffey, Willie Jones. Willie, he had the ugliest feet in baseball, but he was like a father to me. They all were. I'd loved to have stayed, but I spent five years in pro ball, decided I wasn't getting anywhere, and didn't want to spend my life doing it. No regrets, either."

Frank Sullivan? He's the golf pro at Kauai Surf GC in Lihue, Hawaii, trying to forget the agony of a 23-game losing streak.

"Those were awful times for me," he said through the echo of a distant phone line.

"Most of my good times were with Boston, where I was a pretty good pitcher."

"They traded me for Gene Conley. I felt at the time that that meant he was going to the majors and I was going to the minors. I mean, Philly wasn't such a nice place to go back then. Eventually, I went from there to Minnesota to Hawaii. I've been at the golf club for 12 years."

A team goes 30 years between pennants, it tends to have more characters than character.

It is 1980, the Phillies have the National League pennant tucked away, not to mention a two-game lead on Kansas City in the World Series.

If the guys with character are the ones out there playing, the cast of characters from three decades are out there watching, some of them cheering, some of them jeering.

But they're out there ... somewhere in time, most of them doing just fine, thrilled that anybody even remembers.

Uecker's Comic Style Catches On



Uecker then

By PHIL JASNER

Bob Uecker came to the Phillies in 1966. "Dick Groat, Bill White and I came from St. Louis, for Art Mahaffey, Pat Corrales and Alex Johnson," the ABC-TV color man was saying on the phone from his Milwaukee home. "I always said I was a major part of that deal, and I went through with it so I didn't mess up Groat or White's careers."

Uecker's a funny guy who remembers the games he played in, and the ones he didn't. "The subs, we had our own games, before the regulars came out for batting practice," he said. "I was one of the captains, we had maybe four guys to a team, and we'd have somebody judge the hits ... outs, singles, doubles, whatever. At the end of the year, we had a dinner."

Even gave out trophies. I think Harvey Kuenn was my MVP."

AND HOW DOES he see the World Series, with the Phils ahead, 2-0, preparing for Game 3 tonight in Kansas City? "I was a little surprised at the first two games," he replied, "because I thought if the Royals got a lead, they could hold it."

"But I didn't know if (Dan) Quisenberry could hold 'em Wednesday night. He throws like (Pittsburgh's Kent) Tekulve, but not as hard, and it looked like he was gettin' right in their zone. The guy's a good pitcher, though. This was just one night."

"I would think the Royals would be able to turn it around in Kansas City, but the Phils have been playing so great through the Montreal and Houston series, and now in the World

Series. They just look like they're ready."

"Mike Schmidt's starting to hit, the kid (Keith) Moreland could turn out to be a hero, and (Bob) Boone looks so good ... Steve Carlton must've thrown eight in the dirt, and he gets 'em like he knows they're coming. I'd say he's one of the best receivers in baseball."

Catcher, that's the position Uecker played.

"I used to go across the street to the Phillies Bar during the games," he deadpanned. "Get a hoagie, listen to By Sam on the radio. Gene Mauch'd call the bullpen to get somebody ready, they'd put him on hold 'til I got back."

From 1900 to the end of 1979, 1,163 guys played for the Phillies, and only four of them had last names that begin with 'U.' Maybe someday Bob Uecker will tell us about that on "The Tonight Show."



Uecker now